

I. HIGHLIGHTS

Spotlight: Trump-Xi Beijing summit readout

As I told [ARD Tagesthemen](#), [ZDF Morgenmagazin](#), [SRF](#), [Deutschlandfunk](#) and [Handelsblatt](#) during and after the meeting:

- **The summit was rich in theater, but not in substance.** It prioritized atmospherics over deliverables. For China, the primary goals were establishing a “floor” to prevent escalation, buying time and securing advances on Taiwan, while it remains hard to understand what the primary goals were for Trump (or the USG) beyond selected transactional outcomes.
- What sticks are Trump’s effusive comments, which seem more about personal validation-seeking (and family rent-seeking), **allowing Beijing to set the tone and win at least strategic communication points.**
- **No real progress on any of the fundamental questions** has been made. Every substantive deliverable is one-sided. The contested files (Taiwan, chips, AI, Iran) have been pushed out of the written record entirely or asymmetrically. Beijing emerged with “optionality” on every Trump-announced commitment.
- **Taiwan remains the biggest uncertainty.** The PRC readout leads with Taiwan as “the most important issue”, quotes Xi’s “clashes and even conflicts” warning, and explicit demands the US “exercise extra caution”. The US position is muffled and confused by Trump Air Force One comments and a Fox News interview (with some reassurances by M. Rubio).

What that means for Europe

- **Trade and investment diversion:** The bilateral US-China “boards of trade and investment” risk redirecting Chinese import demand toward US goods (hitting German machinery, French luxury, EU industrial exports) and possibly granting US firms preferential access to Chinese financial services and biopharma, structurally disadvantaging European banks, asset managers, and exporters in a market they already struggle to penetrate.
- **Caught between competing legal regimes:** The US MATCH Act (extraterritorial export controls via the Foreign Direct Product Rule) and China’s Decrees 834/835 (countering foreign sanctions, protecting supply chain “security”) put European firms, especially ASML and its German suppliers, in an impossible compliance bind: obey Washington and face Beijing sanctions, or vice versa.
- **Strategic exposure without a seat at the table:** A US willingness to trade away security commitments to Taiwan in exchange for bilateral concessions from Beijing corrodes the credibility of every other American guarantee – from NATO’s Article 5 to backing for Ukraine – and signals that allies are bargaining chips when transactional

deals beckon. Combined with persistent rare earths vulnerability and the absence of a coordinated EU industrial and trade strategy, Brussels risks “managed” status by both powers unless it builds genuine deterrence leverage of its own.

Comparing PRC MFA and White House readouts

- **Shared headline (but incompatible meaning):** Both sides ratified the phrase “constructive China-US relationship of strategic stability”, but with different qualifiers. PRC defines it via four structural dimensions: “positive stability with cooperation as the mainstay”, “healthy stability with competition within proper limits”, “constant stability with manageable differences”, “lasting stability with expectable peace”. The White House attaches it to “fairness and reciprocity”. Same words, two different theories of the relationship: “structural-architectural reset” vs “transactional”.
- **The only bilateral deliverable: the scaffolding of an institutional architecture.** The U.S.-China Board of Trade and Board of Investment appear in both readouts as government-to-government forums for managing non-sensitive goods trade and investment disputes. Everything else is one-sided.
- **Taiwan: in PRC, nothing by WH.** The MFA readout leads with Taiwan as “the most important issue”, quotes Xi’s “clashes and even conflicts” warning, and demands the US “exercise extra caution”. The White House Fact Sheet does not mention Taiwan at all. Beijing made it the headline; Washington deleted it from the written record.
- **Trade specifics: in WH, absent from PRC.** WH itemises hard numbers: at least USD 17 billion per year in US agricultural purchases (2026 prorated, 2027, 2028), 200 Boeing aircraft, more than 400 US beef facilities re-listed, soybean commitments from October 2025 reaffirmed, and a Chinese pledge to “address US concerns regarding supply chain shortages related to rare earths and other critical minerals”. PRC says only that the teams produced “generally balanced and positive outcomes”. Beijing has kept full optionality on every concrete number Trump announced.
- **Iran / Hormuz: US claims joint position but CN remains vague.** WH says both leaders “agreed Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon”, “called to reopen the Strait of Hormuz”, and “agreed no country or organization can be allowed to charge tolls”. PRC says only that leaders “exchanged views on the Middle East situation”. Beijing refused to publicly co-sign anti-Iran or pro-Hormuz language.
- **North Korea: in WH, absent from PRC.** WH says Trump and Xi “confirmed their shared goal to denuclearize North Korea”. PRC readout: nothing on DPRK, ahead of Putin’s Beijing visit days later.

What’s not in

- **Semiconductors and chip export controls: deliberately off the agenda.** Both readouts are silent. USTR Jamieson Greer confirmed post-summit on 15 May: “no talk of chip export controls at the bilateral meeting”. Treasury Secretary Bessent raised the topic only pre-summit with He Lifeng in Seoul.
- **The H200 file seems frozen, but on Beijing’s terms?** Commerce Secretary Lutnick told a Senate hearing that not a single Nvidia H200 has shipped to any of the ten US-approved Chinese buyers. Trump (post-summit): Beijing “chose not to” approve H200

purchases because “they want to develop their own”. The US framing has now flipped: China, not Washington, is the side refusing the chips. Markets read it as “no deal” and sold off Nvidia and Intel sharply.

- **AI: silent in both readouts.** Bessent claimed a US-China framework on non-state-actor access to advanced AI models in his press briefing. Neither gov. confirmed in writing.
- **Fentanyl / drugs: absent from both written records,** despite a joint US-China arrest of five suspects in a drug smuggling case in the run-up to the trip.

Trump on Taiwan (Air Force One and Fox News)
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- “I heard him out. I didn’t make a comment. I made no commitment either way.”
- On Xi’s question about defending Taiwan: “I said, I don’t talk about that.”
- Xi “feels very strongly” and “doesn’t want to see a movement for independence.”
- “We talked the whole night about that issue.”
- Asked if he foresaw a war: “No, I don’t think so. I think we’ll be fine. Xi doesn’t want to see a war.”
- “I think the last thing we need right now is a war that’s 9,500 miles away.”
- On arms package: “I will make a determination... I’ll make a determination over the next fairly short period.”
- “I’m going to say I have to speak to the person ... that’s running Taiwan.”
- “I’m not looking to have somebody go independent. And, you know, we’re supposed to travel 9,500 miles to fight a war. I’m not looking for that.”
- “I want them to cool down. I want China to cool down.”
- “We’re not looking to have wars, and if you kept it the way it is, I think China’s going to be OK with that.”
- “They have somebody there now that wants to go independent. Well, it’s a risky thing when you go independent. They’re going independent because they want to get into a war and ... they figure they have the United States behind them.”
- On US policy framing: “Nothing’s changed” on US policy toward Taiwan.
- On the \$14bn arms package: “I’m holding that in abeyance, and it depends on China. It’s a very good negotiating chip for us, frankly.”
- On Taiwan’s chip industry: “I’d like to see everybody making chips over in Taiwan come into America.” “All of those chip companies, if they’re smart, they’re going to start heading to Arizona and the places where they’re building. That’s going to solve your problems.”

Sources:

- [PRC Ministry of Foreign Affairs – Xi-Trump talks readout](#)
- [White House – Fact Sheet: Historic Deals with China](#)

- [Wang Yi briefing on summit and common understandings](#)
- [Xinhua: 习近平同美国总统特朗普会谈](#)
- [CN MFA: 习近平同特朗普在中南海小范围会晤](#)
- [White House on X: “American strength back on the world stage”](#): (US side video appearing to be a CN propaganda clip)
- [Atlantic Council expert panel: What did Trump and Xi accomplish?](#)
- [CSIS: Trump-Xi Summit in Beijing](#)
- [Noah Barkin: What Xi-Trump means for Europe](#)
- [CBS: Lawmakers press Trump for Taiwan support after Xi summit](#)
- [Foreign Policy: “The Trump-Xi Summit Was Remarkably Banal](#)
- [CFR: “Trump Wraps China Visit”](#)
- [Reuters: “America’s most powerful CEOs don’t have much to show from their China trip so far”](#)
- [WSJ: “Five Takeaways From the Trump-Xi Summit”](#)

German China policy in context

GER

- **Xpeng in talks with VW about buying a factory in Europe** ([FT](#))
- **GER state leaders (Saxony and Lower Saxony) open for CN production in VW factory Zwickau** ([ZDF](#), praise by [Global Times](#))
- **German union urges caution on allowing Chinese carmakers to use VW plants** ([Reuters](#))
- **German town fears impact of industrial decline after chemical giant shifts focus to China** ([HKFP](#))
- **Germany goes from labour shortages to hiring freezes** ([FT](#)): Germany is suffering from rising unemployment as several years of economic stagnation and industrial decline, in part driven by competition from China, finally feed through to the jobs market.
- **Germany turns to Madagascar as Europe races to cut China out of the battery supply chain** ([Africa Business Insider](#))
- **China investor gobbles up 120-year-old German sewing machine maker** ([Nikkei Asia](#))
- **AHK Flash Survey: German firms in China most optimistic since 2023** ([German Chamber of Commerce](#)): 37% predict improvement (+22 pp vs 2025); 61% plan to raise China investments within two years; Iran war hit 75% of operations; 52% cite EU dependency-reduction as their top EU-China business concern.

- **IW Köln: EU sidelined in Trump-Xi Peking summit on tariffs** ([IW](#)): If the US secures preferential rare-earth supply from China, Beijing may tighten Europe-bound restrictions to deter EU action against Chinese market distortions.

EU

- **EU subsidy raids on Chinese company Nuctech were legal, court rules** ([SCMP](#))
- **China orders entities not to comply with EU Nuctec probe** ([Reuters](#))
- **EU Commission plans new squeeze on Chinese trade** ([POLITICO](#)): DG Trade draws up “more assertive and effective trade defense policy”
- **EU plans to force companies to buy parts from non-Chinese suppliers** ([FT](#)): Proposed rules seek to target chemicals and industrial machinery makers
- **Opening Speech by European Union Ambassador to China Mr Jorge Toledo at the 2nd EU-China Conference: navigating beyond the inflection point** ([EEAS](#))
- **A sinking ship? Why the EU and China could be heading for a trade war** ([SCMP](#)): Clashes at a conference in Chinese capital reflect wider tensions that threaten to descend into an economic conflict.
- **Netherlands protests U.S. MATCH Act extending DUV / China-servicing ban for ASML** ([SCMP](#)): The Hague lodged an official objection over the extraterritoriality of the bipartisan US bill.
- **France presses EU to crack down on platforms like Shein and Temu** ([FT](#)): Paris urges EU sanctions up to 4% of annual turnover; 46% of tested foreign-marketplace products were non-conforming or dangerous.

II. MERICS

Publications

MERICS China Industries Brief: “Climate goals for officials + Textile sector + Alcohol industry” ([Link](#), [PDF](#), by A. Brown, A. Mischer, E. Goreichy)

- New State Council measures tie officials’ careers to climate goals
- Textile sector exemplifies how China keeps lower-value industries inside the country
- Beer, wine, and liquor: China is keen to keep spirits high
- Higher launch prices could make Chinese innovative drugs more profitable
- China aims for global leadership in hydrogen

Soapbox Trade: “China’s export surge puts EU trade defence in the spotlight”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **China’s EU surplus surged 26% to \$113bn in the first four months of 2026:** Exports hit a record \$201bn against \$88bn in imports, widening the bilateral imbalance at its fastest recorded pace
- **Tonnes-euros gap flags structural EU dependency on Chinese chemical inputs:** China holds 88% of EU amino acid import volume but only 52% by value, a pattern repeated across feed, food, and pharma-adjacent supply chains
- **EU Commission restricted project funds for Chinese solar inverters on security grounds:** China supplies 87% of EU inverter imports by volume; the Commission cited risks to electricity grids including potential remote shutdown capabilities.

MERICCS Comment: “Xi seeks to buy time as he meets Trump in Beijing”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **Xi’s core summit goal is time-buying, not structural concessions:** The authors argue Beijing will offer tactical wins - commodity purchases, fentanyl pledges, loosened rare earth controls - to forestall further tariff and export control escalation.
- **Structural divergence forecloses any meaningful deal:** China’s state-directed, export-dependent growth model is incompatible with US demands for trade rebalancing, making outcomes beyond marginal gestures structurally unworkable, the article argues.
- **A US-China deal - even a small one - risks redirecting pressure onto Europe:** The authors warn that stabilisation frees both Washington and Beijing to pursue EU economic dependence reduction and renewed tariff pressure respectively.

Selected insights for media by colleagues

- [Nikkei Asia](#), [FAZ](#), [Euronews](#), [Tagesspiegel](#), [AP](#) and [Süddeutsche Zeitung](#) quoted Jacob Gunter and Helena Legarda’s pre-assessment of the Trump-Xi meeting.
- [Global News Morning Toronto](#), [Newsweek](#) and [Deutsche Welle](#) (minute 5:15) asked Claus Soong on Trump’s visit to China.
- [Deutsche Welle](#) asked Rebecca Arcesati on China’s “Regulations on Industrial and Supply Chain Security” providing Beijing with more leverage over companies seeking to de-risk supply chains.

Top Charts/Visuals

2026 Conference on EU-China Relations – Navigating Beyond the Inflection Point, Beijing, 12 May 2026. Bernhard Bartsch moderated the main panel.



2026 Conference on EU-China Relations – panel in Beijing, 12 May 2026

Chart 1 – Beijing ties career prospects of officials to carbon reduction ([MERICS China Industries Brief, May 2026](#))

Beijing ties career prospects of officials to carbon reduction

New performance indicators for top provincial party and state officials



Control indicators

Total carbon emissions

Reduction in carbon emission intensity

Total coal consumption

Total oil consumption

Share of non-fossil energy consumption

Supporting indicators

Reduction in energy consumption per unit of GDP

Share of newly added clean energy electricity in annual new electricity consumption

Reduction in energy consumption and carbon emissions per unit of added value for industrial enterprises above designated size

Implementation of carbon emissions reduction, substitution and energy-saving review for "Two High" projects (high energy consumption & high emissions)

Green and low-carbon transformation in urban and rural construction

Green and low-carbon transformation in transportation

Reduction in carbon emission intensity of public institutions

Coverage of carbon emission control targets in industries under the national carbon emissions trading market

Increase in forest stock volume

Source: MERICS

© MERICS

Beijing ties career prospects of officials to carbon reduction

Chart 2 – China’s industrial exports are on the rise

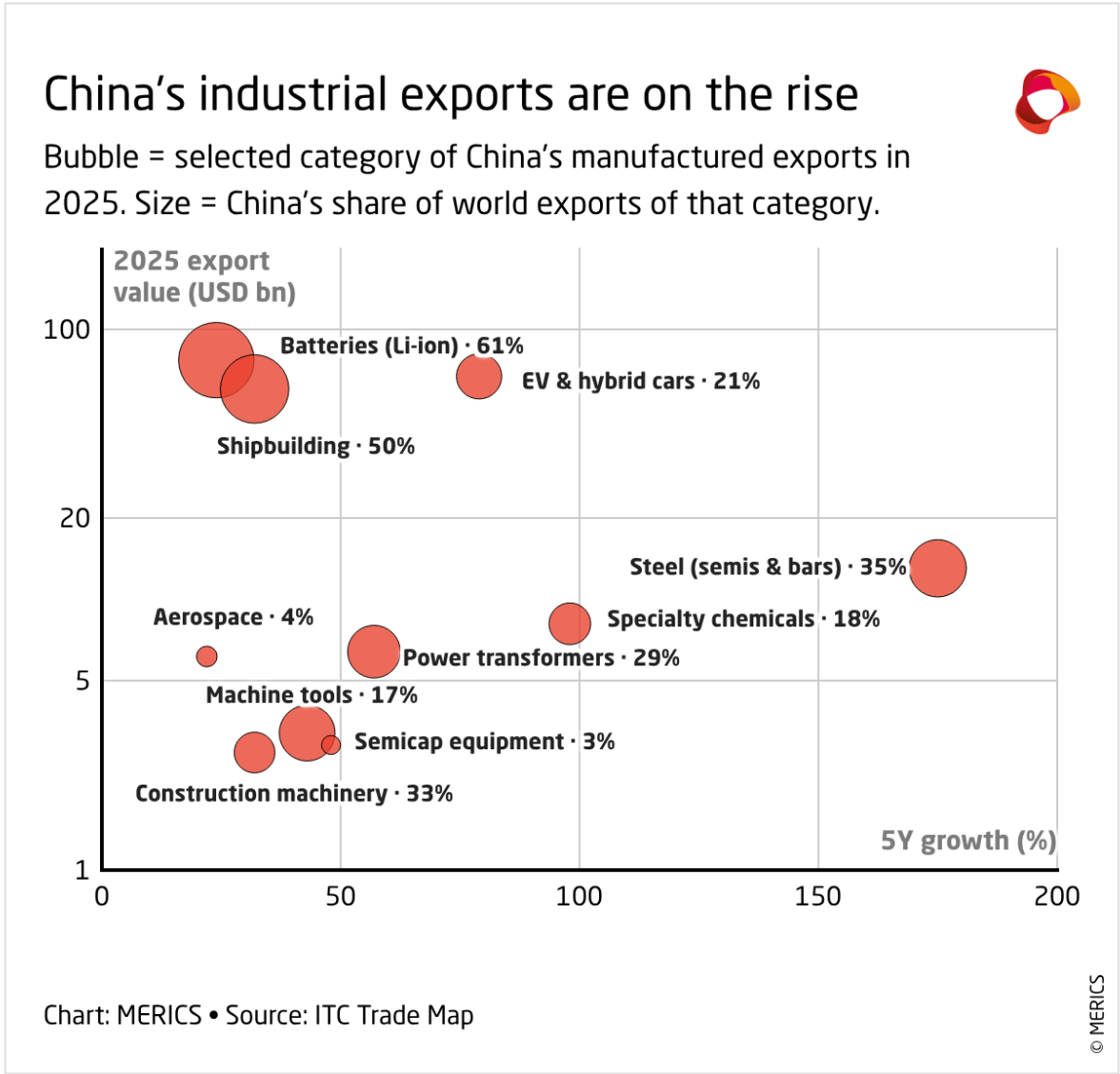


Chart 3 – US-CN trade collapsed 10% y/y across all flows in the four months before the Trump-Xi summit

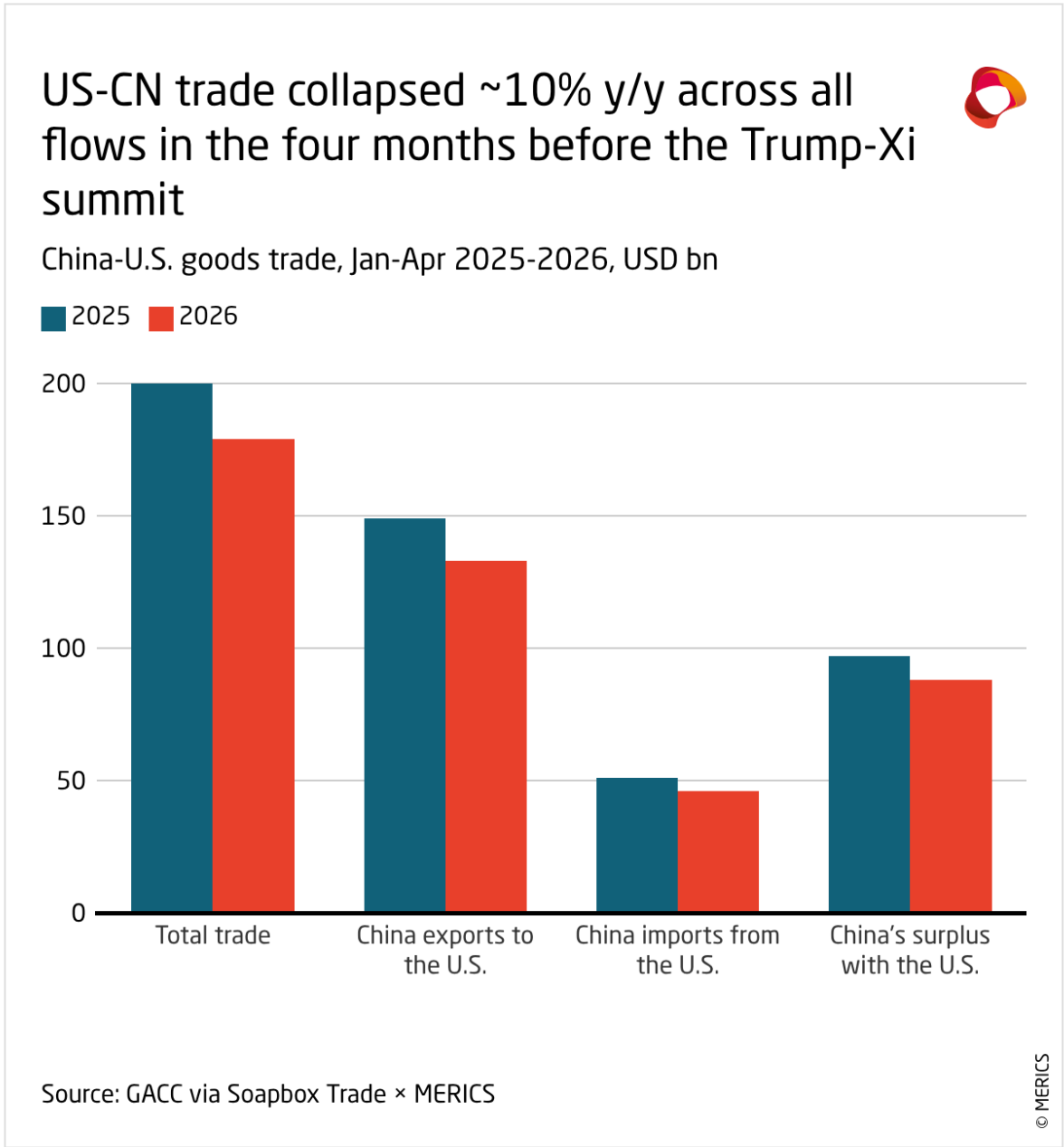


Chart 4 – China sells much more to Germany, while imports from Germany barely rise

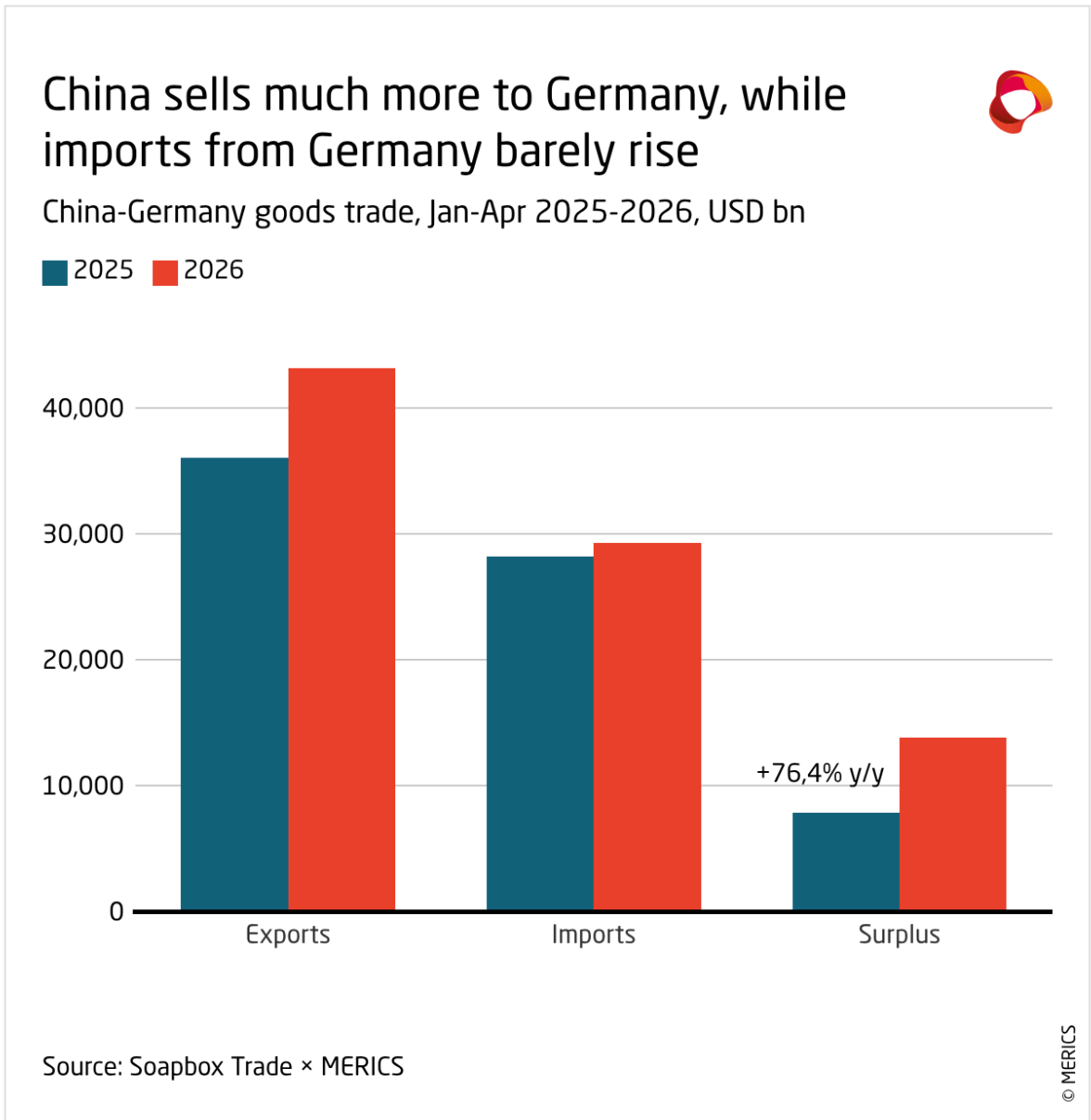


Chart 5 – The EU wants Indium phosphide sovereignty, but the supply trail points to China

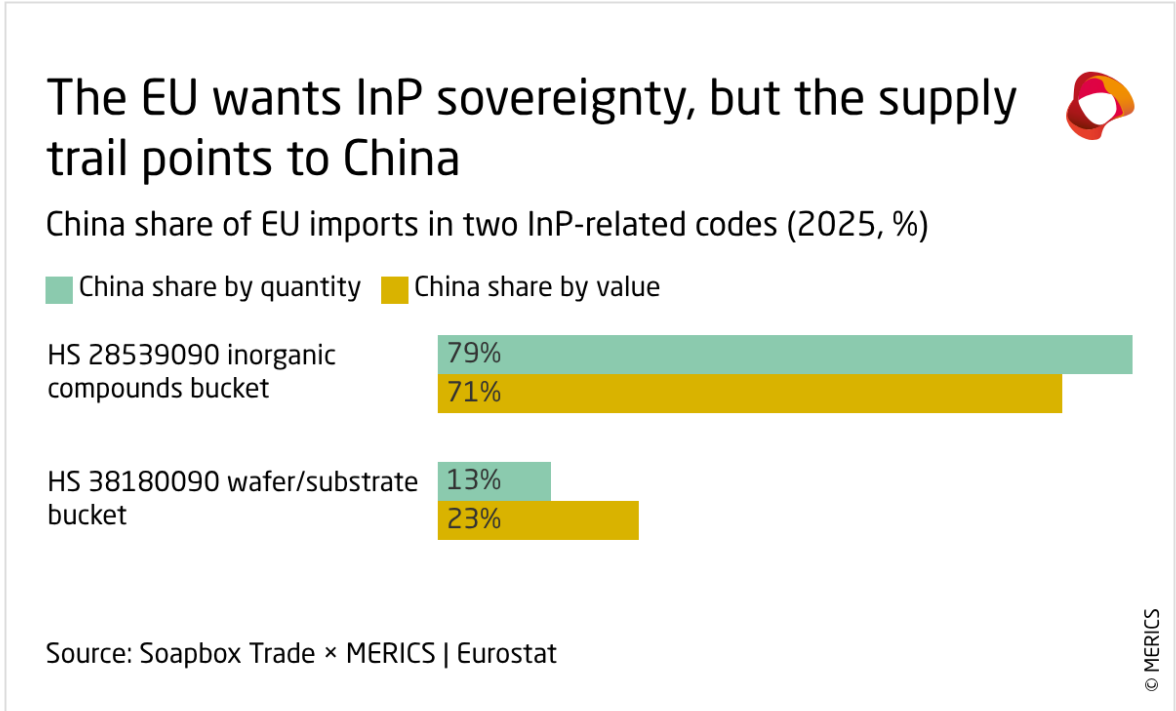
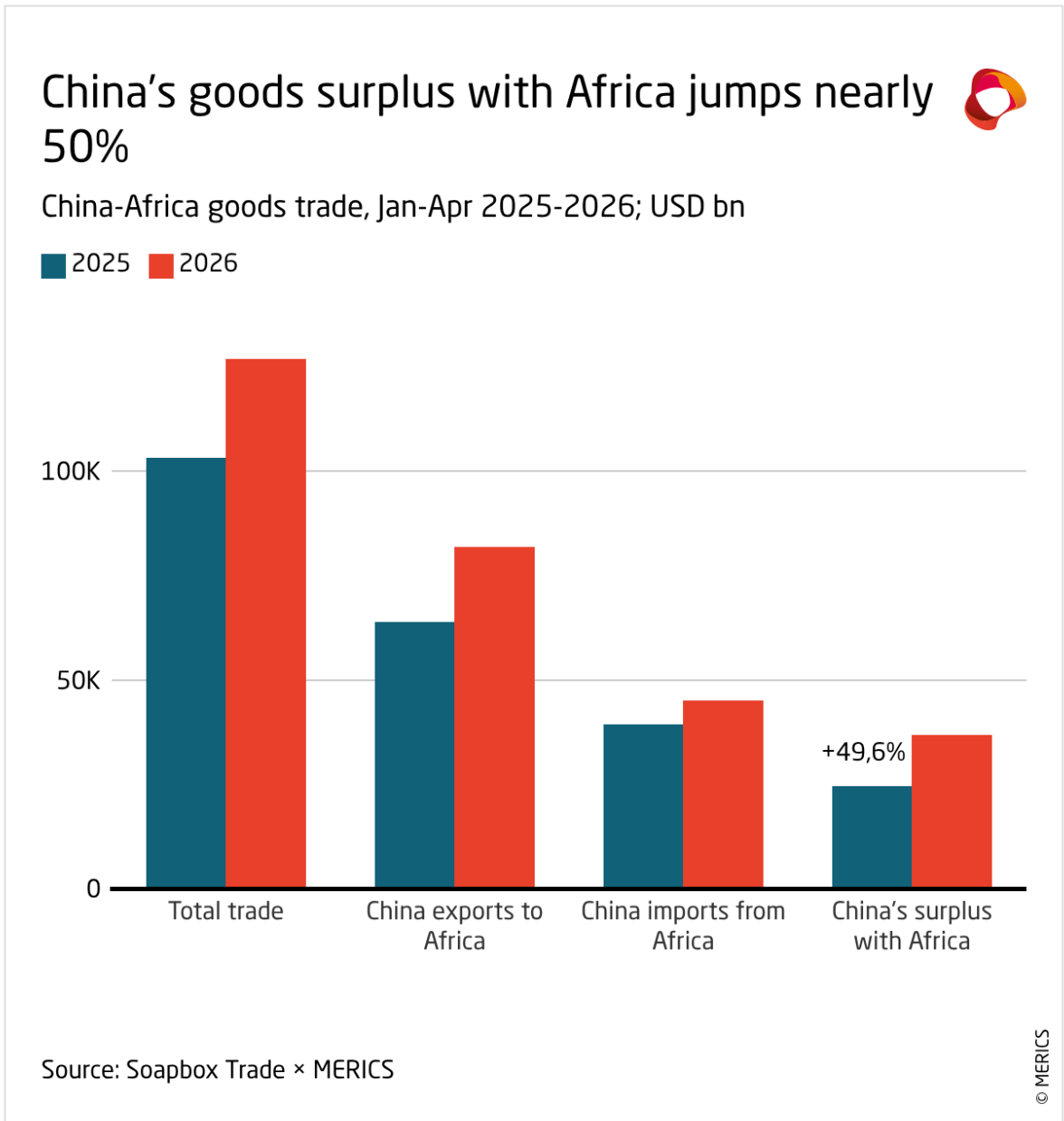


Chart 6 – China’s goods surplus with Africa jumps nearly 50%



Category	HS6 codes
Batteries (Li-ion)	850760
EV & hybrid cars	870380 BEV · 870360 PHEV · 870340 petrol-hybrid
Shipbuilding	890190 cargo · 890120 tankers · 890520 drilling rigs · 890590 other vessels
Steel (semis & bars)	720711/720720 billets · 721391 rods · 720838 hot-rolled flat · 721420 rebar
Specialty chemicals	290919 ethers · 300439 hormone meds · 281820 alumina · 290241 o-xylene · 290323 perchloroethylene

Category	HS6 codes
Power transformers	850421/850422/850423 (liquid-dielectric, three size tiers)
Aerospace	880330 parts · 880240 large aircraft · 880320 undercarriages · 880220 light aircraft
Construction machinery	842641 cranes · 843050 earth-movers · 843049 boring · 842959 excavators
Semi equipment	848620 (semiconductor manufacturing machinery)
Machine tools	846221 NC bending · 845710 machining centres · 845811 NC lathes · 845630 EDM · 845899 other lathes

III. INTERNATIONAL SOURCES

Chinese debates | 1. *Domestic economic situation/policy* | 2. *Politics and society* | 3. *Geoeconomics: tech, AI, semis, rare earths · trade, industry, finance* | 4. *Foreign policy / “Global China”* | 5. *Strategic implications and responses*

Chinese debates

爱思想: “Zhou Li: The US-Israel-Iran Conflict Further Weakens the Unipolar Hegemonic Order”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **The article argues the Iran war exposes US military overstretch:** Zhou Li (a senior strategist) frames the conflict as accelerating the decline of US-led unipolarity by stretching forces and depleting munitions, the piece contends.
- **Beijing positioned as the beneficiary of multipolar drift:** The article reasons that as Washington’s coercive credibility erodes, more Global South states will hedge or align with China rather than risk dependence on US security guarantees.

爱思想: “Yan Xuetong: Projecting the International Order in 2035”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Tsinghua’s Yan Xuetong forecasts bipolar rivalry with shifting blocs by 2035:** The article argues neither pure unipolarity nor multipolarity will dominate; instead, two US- and China-led coalitions of partial overlap will define great-power competition.
- **Yan emphasizes moral leadership as the decisive variable for the next decade:** The piece argues China can only outpace US influence by combining economic statecraft with norms of fair conduct – a “humane authority” framing he has long associated with Xi-era foreign policy.

爱思想: “Huang Yiping: The Nature of China’s Economic Pressure and Strategic Response”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **PKU’s Huang Yiping diagnoses three structural pressures:** Demand insufficiency, supply-chain decoupling, and demographic transition combine to require an integrated rather than sectoral policy response, according to the article.
- **The strategic prescription emphasizes domestic demand expansion plus selective opening:** Huang argues China cannot rebuild external demand through export drives alone; consumption-led rebalancing must be paired with targeted opening to keep foreign investment from fully decoupling.

1. Domestic economic situation/policy

WSJ: “Xi’s China: Dazzling Technology, Military Muscle – and an Economic Mess”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **Military spending doubled; education per pupil rose just 1%:** Defense outlays more than doubled under Xi - rising 7% in 2024 - while per-student education spending grew just over 1% the same year, per government data.
- **Property contraction outpaces strategic sector gains:** Residential construction fell from 16% to 11% of GDP in 2024, while six priority sectors combined rose from only 5.5% to 6.3%, Rhodium Group estimates.
- **China’s social spending sits at half rich-country levels:** At roughly 9% of GDP, China’s social expenditure matches Mexico and Turkey - less than half the share of most wealthy nations, the article reports.

WSJ: “China’s Factory-Gate Price Growth Beats Expectations as Mideast War Fuels Inflation”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **China’s PPI beat April analyst forecasts by 1.1 percentage points:** Middle East tensions kept energy costs elevated, driving the second consecutive monthly gain after a 41-month deflationary cycle ending October 2022.
- **Core CPI hit 1.2% as nonfood prices offset a food-price drop:** Overall consumer inflation came in at 1.2% year-on-year in April, above the 0.8% consensus forecast, with nonfood up 1.8% and food down 1.6%.

Caixin: “China Seeks Stronger Policies for Local Government Debt Cleanup”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **State Council calls for accelerated local government debt cleanup:** China’s cabinet urged stronger policy support to help local governments resolve off-balance-sheet liabilities before a mid-2027 deadline, Caixin reports.

- **Ten-trillion-yuan package targets LGFV debt via swaps, extensions, and rate cuts:** Authorities expanded their 2023 debt-resolution programme with a 10 trillion yuan (\$1.4 trillion) scheme restructuring bank loans, bonds, and non-standard debt.

FT: “Fallout from China housing slowdown grinds on in offshore courts”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Offshore bondholders have recovered just 0.6% of \$150bn in defaulted Chinese property debt:** Debtwire data from early 2025 shows cash recoveries remain near zero five years into the cycle, with tracking made harder by capitalised interest.
- **Debt-to-equity conversion has replaced “amend and extend” as the dominant restructuring structure:** Lawyers at Sidley Austin say creditors now accept equity stakes over fixed repayment timelines, reflecting the absence of a near-term cash flow outlook.
- **Country Garden, Shimao, and Kaisa restructured a combined \$41.8bn in offshore debt in 2025:** Sino-Ocean’s \$6.3bn restructuring became the first completed via an English plan, sanctioned in February 2025 after Hong Kong-based banks accepted while some bondholders resisted.

Bloomberg: “China’s First-Quarter Marriage Registrations Fall to Lowest Ever”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **Q1 2026 marriage registrations hit a record low of 1.697 million couples:** Down 6.2% year-on-year, the figure fell below pandemic-era levels when quarterly registrations exceeded 2 million.
- **Divorce-to-marriage ratio near historic highs as household formation weakens structurally:** With Q1 accounting for nearly a third of annual marriages due to Lunar New Year traditions, the article attributes the decline to structural rather than cyclical factors, with implications for housing demand and consumer spending.

Caixin: “China Overhauls Agriculture Law to Secure Food Supply and Boost Rural Incomes”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **China’s Agriculture Law overhauled for the first time since 2002:** The revised draft, submitted to the NPC Standing Committee, expands the law from 99 to 110 articles and broadens the food security definition to a macro-food approach aligned with the 2023 Food Security Law.
- **Draft codifies income protections for farmers and rural migrant workers:** New provisions mandate equal employment rights, multitiered crop insurance for staple grains, interprovincial compensation transfers for grain-producing regions, and a shift toward unified urban-rural social security coverage.

Caixin: “China Auto Sales Plunge as Domestic Demand Weakens”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **China passenger vehicle sales fell 21.6% year-on-year in April:** Domestic sales reached 1.625 million units, extending a slump that pushed the January - April total down 20.6% to 6.447 million units.
- **Exports surged 74.4% to 901,000 units as domestic demand collapsed:** NEVs reached a 56.3% domestic market share, while forecasts project full-year domestic sales down 7 - 8% against flat or marginally positive total sales.

Nikkei: “China loves food deliveries. Restaurants are starving as a result”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **China’s dine-in restaurant sector in structural decline as delivery cannibalises revenue:** Quanjude’s sales fell 11% and net profit plunged 77% in 2025; Tang Palace posted a net loss for the second consecutive year.
- **Delivery platform price war squeezed restaurant margins across the industry:** Meituan, Alibaba, and JD.com spent 74.4 billion yuan on promotions in six months, with nearly 80% of surveyed restaurants reporting profit declines as a result.
- **Frugality rules and weak consumer spending compound the structural shift:** A 2025 ban on expensive official dinners hit high-end chains hardest while 630 million consumers shifted toward discounted delivery options.

Caixin: “Executives Flee, Workers Strike at Wahaha’s Production Operator”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Four senior Hongsheng Beverage executives departed simultaneously:** Wahaha’s main production and sales operator lost its heads of sales, legal affairs, production management, and the president’s office director amid an ongoing control reshuffle, according to Caixin sources.
- **Labor unrest spread to multiple Wahaha facilities over pay cuts:** A 75-worker Hubei strike over 130-yuan average payouts and a Jilin suicide attempt over severance led more than 1,000 employees to plan arbitration.
- **Wahaha sales fell 20% in the first four months of 2026:** The revenue drop coincides with the management exodus and widespread labor disputes at Hongsheng Beverage, Wahaha’s main operating arm.

2. Politics and society

Ac: “Xi Jinping’s Struggle Against Party Indiscipline in China”, 2026-05-06, [Link](#)

- **Party disciplinary cases topped one million in 2025, a record:** The article reports this as evidence that cadre indiscipline remains endemic despite over a decade of anti-corruption campaigns under Xi.

- **Tighter oversight produces policy inaction rather than correcting behaviour:** Fear of investigation prompts officials to await instructions rather than respond proactively, according to Qiushi, the Party's authoritative journal.
- **Ideology sets priorities but implementation remains structurally weak:** The article argues broad Xi Thought priorities require local contextualisation that endemic risk aversion and fiscal pressures on local governments prevent.

Caixin: "Former Top Chinese Anti-Graft Official Indicted on Bribery Charges", 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Ex-Ningxia discipline chief indicted on two bribery counts:** Xu Chuazhi, former deputy-ministerial CCDI inspector, will stand trial in Ningbo for taking especially huge bribes during and after his official tenure.
- **Two subordinates convicted before Xu's own trial:** Yin Xueru was sentenced to 11 years and Jiang Zhigang to 15 years for bribery in 2023 and 2024 respectively.

Foreign Policy: "Beijing's Quest for Uniformity May Be Its Achilles' Heel", 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **New ethnic unity law mandates Mandarin instruction in minority schools:** China's Law on Promoting Ethnic Unity and Progress, effective July 2026, extends Xi's Sinicization push across Tibetan, Uyghur, and Mongolian regions.
- **Churches and mosques ordered to remove Christian and Islamic symbols:** Under Xi's "Sinicization of religion" policy, crosses, domes, and minarets must be replaced by CCP-approved iconography, the article reports.
- **The author argues forced uniformity will cost China global influence:** Suppressing minority languages and political freedoms undermines the soft power China needs for international leadership, while BRI infrastructure alone cannot substitute for legitimacy, the piece contends.

X: "Post by @ZhangTaisu on X", 2026-05-17, [Link](#)

- **Academic censorship in Beijing back to early-1990s levels:** The author reports sharp humanities funding cuts and a proliferating list of political red lines among Beijing academics over the past two years.
- **Industry contacts say overseas expansion is the only profit avenue:** Domestic consumption remains depressed despite government stimulus, forcing major firms to rely on direct overseas investment, the author reports.
- **Youth pessimism at Beijing's elite universities at historic levels:** The author reports unprecedented career anxiety at Tsinghua and PKU, with very low willingness to form families or plan ahead.

Caixin: “Elite Chinese University Fires Researchers Over Faked Nature Study”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **Tongji University dismissed dean and researcher for data fabrication:** Wang Ping was demoted and Jin Jiali fired on May 6 after Tongji confirmed intentional fraud in their 2025 Nature cancer paper.
- **PubPeer flagged statistically impossible data patterns in the study:** Scholars identified results with probabilities as low as 10^{-23} and 1.5×10^{-32} , consistent with data reverse-engineered from desired outcomes.
- **Two other elite universities launched simultaneous misconduct probes:** Nankai and Sun Yat-sen Universities opened separate Nature paper fraud investigations in early May 2026, the article reports.

Caixin: “Beijing Rolls Out Sweeping Crackdown on Pharmaceutical Kickbacks”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **Seven agencies issued binding rules redefining pharma reps as academic promoters:** The Pharmaceutical Representative Management Measures, effective August 1, ban sales tasks, prescription tracking, and performance-linked payments, covering 116,000 registered representatives.
- **Bribery prosecution threshold cut 50% under concurrent judicial interpretation:** A May 1 Supreme Court directive introduces criminal liability for companies, while historical kickbacks ran to roughly 30% of drug prices, according to Caixin.

Guardian: “Chinese court awards compensation to sacked worker replaced by AI”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Hangzhou court orders 260,000 yuan to AI-replaced worker:** The court ruled a tech company wrongfully dismissed a quality assurance supervisor after claiming AI could perform his role.
- **Beijing’s AI messaging shifts to address unemployment concerns:** A Brookings Institution fellow said official framing has moved from job-creation optimism toward language acknowledging AI-driven job losses.

3a. Geoeconomics: Tech, AI, semis, rare earths

RAND: “China’s Science and Technology Strategy”, 2026-05-05, [Link](#)

- **Xi’s doctrine shifts China from tech importation to domestic mastery:** RAND finds Beijing now prioritises domestic mastery of AI, semiconductors, and advanced manufacturing over technology importation under Xi Jinping’s self-reliance framework.
- **Military-civil fusion merges civilian and defence science into one mobilisation system:** The integrated structure accelerates technological progress but blurs

research security boundaries, complicating institutional autonomy in international scientific collaboration.

- **China targets technical standards in 5G and AI as geopolitical instruments:** Beijing seeks leadership in emerging technology standards to project industrial and geopolitical influence, the report finds.

Caixin: “China Issues Guidelines to Standardize AI Agent Development”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **CAC, NDRC, and MIIT jointly issued AI agent development guidelines:** The framework targets 70% adoption of AI agents in smart terminals by 2027, according to Caixin.
- **Beijing blocked Meta’s \$2 billion acquisition of AI startup Manus:** China ordered the parties to unwind the deal following a foreign investment security review, the article reports.

Nikkei: “The AI space race: US and China bet big on orbital data centers”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **US and China both targeting orbital data centers as AI’s next infrastructure frontier:** Google, Nvidia, and startups are racing to build solar-powered space-based data centers, with Asia’s supply chain mobilising to support the effort, the article reports.
- **Google engineer spent two years resisting the space data center concept:** Travis Beals initially dismissed a colleague’s proposal to site data centers in orbit before, according to Nikkei, eventually coming round to the idea.

NYT: “China Seeks A.I. Independence, Weakening Trump’s Leverage”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **DeepSeek ran its latest model on Huawei chips for the first time:** The milestone gave Beijing confidence ahead of the Trump-Xi summit that U.S. export controls on Nvidia hardware have not halted Chinese AI development.
- **No Nvidia H200 chips have actually reached China despite Trump’s export clearance:** Commerce Secretary Lutnick told Congress no deliveries had occurred, and Nvidia reported zero China revenue from the chips.
- **SMIC chips remain defect-prone and consume more power than foreign rivals:** Huawei compensates by clustering weaker chips, though Chinese producers are expected to make only a small fraction of advanced chips this year.

WSJ: “China’s Best and Brightest Tech Talent Is Going Back to China”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Meta’s April layoffs prompted Beijing recruiters to target laid-off engineers:** A Beijing-based headhunter flew to Menlo Park to recruit China-born talent from Meta, Google, Anthropic, and Amazon back to China, the article reports.

- **Chinese tech firms authorise Silicon Valley-matching salaries to repatriate engineers:** Clients are promising compensation equal to or above U.S. rates - a significant windfall given China's lower cost of living - to fuel Beijing's AI, robotics, and medical research push.

NYT: "China Sought Access to Anthropic's Newest A.I. The Answer Was No.", 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Chinese think tank requested Mythos access at Carnegie Singapore dialogue:** Anthropic refused, and NSC officials reacted with alarm, viewing the outreach as almost certainly Beijing-directed, according to people briefed on the discussions.
- **US AI lead over China widened to an estimated 9-12 months:** Anthropic's Mythos and OpenAI's ChatGPT 5.5 have extended the gap from a prior six-month estimate, though some officials caution Beijing closes gaps quickly.
- **AI and cybersecurity placed high on Trump-Xi summit agenda:** A senior US official said both sides are exploring a "deconfliction" channel for expert-level AI risk communication, separate from chip access or export controls.

SCMP: "Top Singapore-based physicist relocates to China after superconductor breakthrough", 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Zhejiang University recruited Singapore's top young physicist via structured talent scheme:** Stephen Lin Er Chow, 27, left NUS for the "100 Young Professors" programme as principal investigator following his copper-free superconductor breakthrough.
- **Chow's 2025 Nature paper was the NUS lab's first top-tier result in twenty years:** The finding demonstrated a copper-free oxide achieving high-temperature superconductivity, the advance that attracted Zhejiang's recruitment offer.

Caixin: "China Establishes New Agency for the Low-Altitude Economy", 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **CAAC establishes 30-person Low-Altitude Safety Department:** The new unit will formulate development plans for commercial low-altitude airspace, including flight dispatch platforms, safety coordination, and service stations.
- **Second ministry-level low-altitude body follows NDRC's December 2024 division:** The department will translate macro strategies into civil aviation rules, airworthiness certification, and airspace standards, an industry executive told Caixin.

Nikkei: "India's nascent semiconductor sector faces China's push in older chips", 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **China's mature-node capacity growth outpaced global demand fourfold from 2015 to 2023:** Chinese chipmakers are projected to account for nearly half of new mature-node capacity over the next three to five years, according to a U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission report.

- **India's first fab targets the same legacy chip segment China is flooding:** Tata Electronics' \$11 billion Gujarat facility will compete directly with Chinese producers who can price legacy chips 30% below market rate, analysts warn.

Nikkei: "How a year of China's rare-earth controls is reshaping supply chains", 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **China's rare-earth magnet exports fell 4% by volume in the year after April 2025 controls:** Nikkei Asia's analysis of customs data shows shipments dropped to 58.1 million kilograms, while compound exports fell 17% in value.
- **Defense-sector buyers unable to obtain materials as licensing excludes national security end-uses:** Western manufacturers in commercial sectors have adapted through stockpiling and design changes, but Beijing's dual-use regime blocks supply to defense-linked companies outright.
- **Alternative supply chains accelerating outside China:** Australia's Lynas, Canada's Neo Performance Materials, and U.S. Energy Fuels commissioned new heavy rare-earth separation capacity, with demand for non-Chinese sources building ahead of a U.S. defense procurement ban taking effect January 2027.

Geopolitechs: "Nuctech Case And A Clash Between China's Anti-Extraterritorial Blocking Rules and the EU's FSR", 2026-05-16, [Link](#)

- **China's Ministry of Justice blocked cooperation with the EU's Nuctech FSR probe:** Beijing's new anti-extraterritoriality regulations prohibit any entity from assisting EU cross-border data requests, effective May 15.
- **EU data demands extended to email servers physically located in China:** Commission investigators sought access to Nuctech's Beijing headquarters systems, creating a direct conflict between EU investigative authority and Chinese data security law.
- **EU "facts available" doctrine consistently applied in Chinese data refusal cases:** Across solar, steel, and paper anti-subsidy investigations, EU courts upheld Commission adverse inferences when Chinese firms invoked domestic law to withhold evidence.

SCMP: "Chinese aviation expert lays out plan to sanction-proof domestic passenger planes", 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **C919 "father" publishes sanction-proofing blueprint for large passenger jets:** Zhang Yanzhong, former AVIC chief scientist, warned of a real risk of being cut off from Western aviation components.
- **Blueprint reveals C919's critical reliance on U.S. and French aerospace suppliers:** Engines, avionics, flight controls, brakes, and hydraulics all depend on GE, Honeywell, Collins Aerospace, Parker Hannifin, and Moog.

CFR: “China and Climate: China Restricts Fuel Exports, Solar Exports Surge”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Binding carbon evaluation rules introduced for China’s provincial governments:** Authorities must develop “carbon peaking action plans” assessed on 14 indicators - including total emissions, coal and oil consumption, and non-fossil energy share - to be administered by the NDRC.
- **CCP-State Council opinion prescribes stricter fossil fuel controls:** The non-binding document calls to “strictly control fossil fuel consumption” and mandates monitoring mechanisms including “alerts for lagging progress” on energy savings and carbon targets.

3b. Geoeconomics: Trade, industry, finance

Nikkei: “China’s EcoFlow to sell solar panels in British supermarkets soon”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **EcoFlow named UK government partner for household solar rollout:** The Shenzhen manufacturer will sell plug-in solar panels through British supermarkets as part of the UK’s warm homes and net-zero programme.
- **UK regulatory barriers and security concerns complicate market entry:** Unlike EU markets where plug-in systems are legal, UK rules require licensed electrician installation; the government separately blocked Chinese turbine maker Ming Yang over national security.

Nikkei: “China solar panel maker Jinko to sell majority stake in US unit for \$191m”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **JinkoSolar sells 75.1% of its U.S. unit for \$191.5 million:** Chinese solar manufacturer JinkoSolar agreed to transfer majority control of its Florida factory to American private equity firm FH Capital in a three-tranche deal.
- **Trump’s removal of Biden-era subsidies for Chinese-owned clean energy factories is forcing a wave of divestments:** Multiple Chinese solar and battery firms - including CSI Solar, Boviet Solar, and JA Solar - have sold or are selling U.S. manufacturing stakes under the same pressure.

FT: “China’s exports jump 14% ahead of Xi Jinping-Donald summit”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **April export growth rebounded sharply, beating analyst forecasts:** Growth rose to 14.1% year-on-year from 2.5% in March - well above the 8.5% median forecast - according to China’s General Administration of Customs.
- **Iran war commodity prices drove Chinese import costs up 25.3%:** Petrochemical feedstock shortages are hitting Chinese industries dependent on Hormuz oil, despite China’s record pre-conflict stockpiles, the FT reports.

FT: “The Chinese investment plan that Trump held back”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **China floated a \$1tn U.S. investment deal pre-election:** G7 capitals received intelligence suggesting Beijing was negotiating the package with the Trump camp before November 2024, according to ECIPE director Lee-Makiyama.
- **Security restrictions make large-scale Chinese FDI recovery in the U.S. unlikely:** Rhodium Group concludes policy barriers mean newly announced Chinese investment will not return to mid-2010s peaks, with Beijing redirecting flows toward lower-income markets.

FT: “Chinese demand spurs U.S. ethane exports to record high”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **U.S. ethane exports hit a record 776,000 b/d in March, with 72% going to China:** The surge was driven by China’s plastics industry switching from naphtha - disrupted by Iran war oil supply cuts - to cheaper U.S. ethane feedstock.
- **Energy Transfer extended existing ethane contracts by ten years to 2041:** The Texas midstream company cited strong Chinese demand as it expands capacity at its Nederland Terminal, one of the largest U.S. natural gas liquids export facilities.

Nikkei: “China carmakers get most subsidies; U.S.-sanctioned oil refiner also benefits”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Great Wall and BYD led A-share subsidy recipients in 2025:** Great Wall received 3.7 billion yuan (up 33%), representing nearly 40% of its net profit, while BYD received 2.51 billion yuan despite a 33.5% decline.
- **Total Chinese corporate subsidies fell 8.6% to 189.1 billion yuan:** Local government fiscal pressure - linked to collapsed land-sale revenues since 2022 - drove the overall decline, though funding remained concentrated in high-tech and self-reliance priorities.
- **U.S.-sanctioned oil refiner Hengli Petrochemical ranked among top recipients:** The company received 1.64 billion yuan - 2.6 times its 2023 level - despite alleged Iranian crude purchases that triggered U.S. Treasury sanctions in April 2026.

Guardian: “Seven-day weeks and ‘debt bondage’: China’s first electric car plant in Europe mired in allegations of worker abuse”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **China Labor Watch reported EU labour law violations at BYD’s Szeged construction site:** Fifty-plus migrant workers cited seven-day weeks, recruitment fees up to £2,100 - constituting debt bondage, the group says - and excessive overtime.
- **BYD confirmed a fatal accident and faces a pending Hungarian labour inspectorate case:** The European Commission said it was aware of the allegations, with three MEPs formally raising the matter in Brussels.

- **CATL's plans for 2,000 Chinese construction workers in Zaragoza drew similar local opposition:** The company's vice-president said experienced technicians - not a local-bypass policy - were needed to set up production lines.

FT: "China expanding its industrial dominance, warns US business group", 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **US Chamber warns of narrowing supply chain response window:** China's goods trade surplus has doubled to \$2tn since 2019, according to a Rhodium Group report commissioned by the chamber.
- **Rhodium frames Beijing's approach as "industrial policy of everything":** State support is extending supply chain dominance from EVs and clean energy into chemicals, machinery, and robotics, the report says.
- **Lead author flags China eroding advanced economies' technological edges:** Camille Boullenois told the FT that China is gaining market share in chemicals, autos, and robotics faster than governments are responding.

DW: "China's new rules give the West a new headache", 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **New supply chain rules let Beijing retaliate for Western compliance:** China can now fine and blacklist foreign firms that comply with U.S. or EU export controls targeting Chinese entities, the report states.
- **EU Chamber flags impossible compliance bind for multinationals:** Chamber president Eskelund described the measures as an "extraterritorial toolbox" creating situations where firms cannot simultaneously satisfy Chinese and Western regulatory demands.
- **EU's Industrial Accelerator Act targets Chinese supply dependencies amid pushback:** Published in March, the IAA aims to cut reliance on Chinese goods, but Germany and other member states are urging a more cautious approach.

Foreign Policy: "China's Malacca Dilemma, After Hormuz", 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Western insurers, not warships, can choke China's oil supply:** The article argues JWC war-risk designations can make tanker transit commercially unviable without any naval engagement.
- **Malacca listing requires only a credible threat, not actual conflict:** The JWC listed Malacca in 2005 over discredited terrorism claims - a Taiwan war designation could cripple China's 80% oil transit dependency.
- **China's insurance countermeasures fall far short of Lloyd's scale:** Hong Kong's war-risk pool covered just 10 ships at \$130 million capacity in 2026, insufficient to insure a single modern tanker.

FT: “China fixes currency at 3-year high ahead of Trump-Xi meeting”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **PBoC set renminbi fixing at three-year high:** The rate of RMB 6.8467 per dollar was the strongest since March 2023; the bank simultaneously fixed weaker than expected to curb speculative appreciation bets ahead of the Trump-Xi summit.
- **Goldman Sachs estimates the renminbi is undervalued by around 20%:** China’s external surplus is approaching unprecedented levels as a share of global GDP, reflecting deep export competitiveness and structural currency misalignment, the bank said.
- **April CPI and PPI data signal China’s deflation easing:** Consumer prices rose 1.2% and producer prices 2.8% year-on-year; oil-sector prices jumped 18.5% month-on-month following Iran war supply-chain disruptions.

Caixin: “Citigroup to Get License for Wholly Owned China Securities Firm as CEO Joins Trump Visit”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Citigroup wins CSRC approval for a wholly owned mainland securities firm:** The firm becomes the seventh foreign institution with full brokerage ownership in China, joining JPMorgan, Goldman Sachs, UBS, Standard Chartered, BNP Paribas, and Mizuho.
- **Approval follows a four-year review and coincides with CEO Fraser joining Trump’s Beijing delegation:** Citigroup filed the application in December 2021, the CSRC accepted it in December 2023, and the review concluded during the Trump-Xi summit week.

FT: “Schroders plans to exit China mutual funds business after just three years”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Schroders exiting wholly owned China fund unit after three years:** The FT reports the company will transfer its licence - obtained in 2023 under regulatory easing - while retaining its Bank of Communications joint venture.
- **Foreign asset managers struggle to gain China market traction:** Vanguard exited its mainland joint venture in 2023; Z-Ben Advisors describes the sector as “a slog and a struggle for multiple years.”

Trivium: “Pakistan to join booming panda bond market”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Pakistan to raise up to RMB 1.75bn in its first panda bond sale:** Finance Minister Muhammad Aurangzeb confirmed the issuance - in China’s onshore RMB-denominated bond market - could launch as early as this week, according to SCMP.

FT: “China to produce Jeep and Peugeot cars under €1bn Dongfeng deal”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Stellantis and Dongfeng seal €1bn Wuhan NEV joint venture:** Two Peugeot electric models and two Jeep hybrids will roll off Wuhan lines from 2027 for domestic and export markets, with Stellantis contributing €130mn.
- **Western carmakers’ China market share fell from 64% to 30% last year:** The article reports the deal reflects growing Western dependence on Chinese partners for EV software, batteries, and autonomous vehicle systems.

Nikkei: “Honda and Toyota see sharp Chinese sales drops as competition heats up”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Honda China sales collapsed 48% in April, Toyota dropped 25%:** Both Japanese automakers cited slow model updates, rising gasoline prices from the Iran war, and intensifying local competition as drivers.
- **Toyota EV sales bucked the trend, rising 88% to 17,700 units:** Overall China vehicle sales fell 20% in the first four months, compounded by reduced NEV tax exemptions.

4. Foreign policy / “Global China”

Handelsblatt: “Antelope Reef: China baut seinen Einflussring im Südchinesischen Meer aus”, , [Link](#)

- **China builds airstrip at Antelope Reef:** Satellite imagery shows a runway and new infrastructure under construction at the reef between January and May 2026, the article reports.
- **Beijing targets regional reach over global military footprint:** Outposts, ports, and airfields along key sea routes are designed to extend PLA operational range and complicate rival military access, Handelsblatt reports.

NYT: “As Their Leaders Meet, American and Chinese People Are Drifting Apart”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **U.S.-China student flows have collapsed since 2019:** Fewer than 2,000 Americans study in China today, down from 11,000, as India overtook China as the top U.S. student-sender country.
- **Trump slashed exchange funding and threatened Chinese student visa revocations:** Beijing meanwhile loosened tourist visas and hosted American athletes marking the 55th anniversary of ping pong diplomacy.

The Atlantic: “China Believes America Will Flame Out”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **China bets on US self-exhaustion over direct confrontation:** The article argues Beijing views American political decay and military overextension as sufficient to produce a global leadership vacuum without any direct Chinese challenge.
- **Wang Huning’s US decline thesis now underpins official CCP strategy:** His 1990s book diagnosing American social fragmentation informs China’s leadership approach as a Politburo Standing Committee member and Xi Jinping adviser, the article reports.
- **China’s patience strategy rests on domestic assumptions showing strain:** Deflationary overcapacity, record youth unemployment, and demographic decline complicate a grand strategy premised on China outlasting American decline, the article reports.

NYT: “China Increasingly Views Trump’s America as an Empire in Decline”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Renmin University-linked institute published a report titled “Thank Trump”:** The January paper credited Trump’s domestic and foreign policy blunders with accelerating U.S. institutional decay and China’s strategic self-reliance.
- **“American decline” rhetoric in Chinese official sources nearly doubled in 2025:** A Brookings study tracked the surge as Trump’s second term supplied state propaganda with fresh material.
- **Chinese official statements treated Biden as systemic threat, Trump as transactional:** AI analysis of 7,000 statements since 2021 found Xi reserved “encirclement and suppression” language for Biden’s presidency, not Trump’s.

Foreign Affairs: “China Is Squandering a Golden Opportunity”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Countries hedge against both superpowers, not pivoting to Beijing:** The authors argue Trump’s global estrangement has produced hedging rather than Chinese gains, making U.S.-China competition non-zero-sum.
- **China’s structural limits impede filling U.S. geostrategic vacuums:** The authors identify no real allies, poor soft power returns, and limited military projection as Beijing’s core deficits.
- **Europe has proved particularly resistant to Chinese advances:** Beijing’s Russia partnership, espionage cases, and a €360 billion EU trade deficit block China from exploiting European estrangement from Washington.

Nikkei: “China spy case in Norway exposes weaknesses in Europe’s Arctic front”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **PST arrested Chinese national near Norway’s Andoya spaceport:** Police seized a 22-ton data receiver allegedly intended to capture polar-orbit satellite signals on behalf of a Chinese state actor.

- **Satellite encryption is structurally thin due to hardware weight limits:** Telenor's threat intelligence VP said CPU and encryption capacity are kept lean to reduce mass, leaving signals vulnerable to interception.
- **Chinese tourist surge raises grey-zone surveillance concerns:** Chinese overnight stays in Norway rose 78% year-on-year to 392,000, with analysts warning intelligence operators may enter covertly as tourists.

Foreign Affairs: "China Was Ready for the Age of Anarchy", 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **China's security minister ordered a full-chain overseas protection system:** Minister Chen Yixin directed intelligence, law enforcement, and forward security assets to defend BRI projects and supply chains against rising disruption risk, the article reports.
- **Party-linked intellectuals are debating formal revision of China's noninterference doctrine:** Zheng Yongnian's "Interventionism 2.0" would authorise extraterritorial law enforcement and potential military force to protect Chinese assets abroad, according to the author.

Nikkei: "China widens oil purchases to extend influence from US to Iran", 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **China expanded crude oil sourcing to offset Gulf supply losses:** Saudi imports fell 30% and Iraqi imports dropped in Q1 2026 after Iran's de facto Hormuz blockade, while Russian crude rose to 22% of total imports, up from 17% in 2025.
- **Beijing timed 15 U.S. crude tanker arrivals to coincide with Trump's summit visit:** According to diplomatic sources cited by Nikkei, China is offering large-scale U.S. energy purchases as a transactional concession while continuing Iranian oil imports via ship-to-ship transfers off Indonesia.

Bloomberg: "China's Secretive Missile Program Is Making Dozens of Companies Rich", 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **37.5% of Chinese missile suppliers posted record revenues in 2025:** Bloomberg's analysis of 81 listed firms shows aggregate sector sales rose 20% to 189 billion yuan, outpacing China's broader economy.
- **China's ballistic missile count rose 147% from 2015 to 2024, Pentagon estimates:** The buildup to 3,150 missiles gives Beijing a growing stockpile advantage as the Iran war depletes US reserves.

SCMP: "China's 'dark factory' more than doubles production efficiency for J-20 jets", 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Chengdu dark factory more than doubles J-20 skeleton production efficiency:** Autonomous vehicles and AI-driven machinery produce stealth fighter components near-continuously with minimal human involvement, Science and Technology Daily reports.

- **J-20, declared combat-ready in 2018, entered mass production in 2020:** The fifth-generation stealth fighter built by AVIC subsidiary Chengdu Aircraft Corporation contains thousands of unique components, all now produced in the lights-out facility.

SCMP: “Chinese company that tracked U.S. bombers over Iran wears sanctions with pride”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **U.S. Treasury sanctioned Chinese OSINT firm MizarVision for tracking American bombers:** Washington added the Hangzhou-based satellite imagery start-up to its SDN list for publishing open-source images of U.S. military activity during Operation Epic Fury over Iran.
- **MizarVision posted a recruitment ad featuring the Treasury sanctions notice:** The company framed the designation as a badge of honour, calling on applicants who “turn pressure into productivity.”

FAZ: “Donald Trump in China: Xi Jinping lässt den US-Präsidenten auflaufen”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Xi asked Trump directly whether the US would defend Taiwan:** Trump gave a deliberately ambiguous answer; Eurasia Group analyst Dan Wang called it the strongest Chinese pressure on Washington over Taiwan to date.
- **Trump’s summit deals matched packages already offered to Macron and Merz:** No agreements went beyond aviation, agriculture, and energy - the three sectors Beijing uses as strategic chips with all major Western partners, FAZ reports.

Guardian: “Experts believe breakthrough in U.S. fentanyl crisis may have started in China”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **Science study links US overdose decline to Chinese precursor disruptions:** A study in Science correlates a sharp fall in fentanyl purity in US seizures from May 2023 with a more-than-one-third drop in overdose deaths by November 2025.
- **China’s 2019 fentanyl ban drove supply chains toward Mexican cartels:** Experts warn supply shocks are temporary - Beijing’s ban prompted cartels to import Chinese precursors and traffic the finished product across the US-Mexico border.
- **Fentanyl enforcement measures expected to feature at Trump-Xi summit:** Experts cited in the article urge China to amend trafficking laws and enforce export controls on precursor chemicals through its commerce ministry.

ChinaTalk: “Macartney to Mar-a-Lago”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Gewirtz frames the summit as a “stalemate” shaped by Maoist staying-power logic:** Beijing views de-escalation as a tactical pause in sustained competition, not a strategic shift, according to the author.
- **Gewirtz’s competing Iran briefings conclude the war is net positive for China:** US munitions depletion, clean energy demand surge, and summit-tied ceasefire optics outweigh economic disruption costs, he argues.

- **Beijing's Taiwan pressure targets Taiwanese morale and the 2028 election via incremental language shifts:** China seeks gradual declaratory concessions rather than overnight policy reversals, with the Taiwanese public as the primary audience, Gewirtz argues.

SCMP: "Russia's Putin is heading to China next week, days after historic Xi- Trump summit", 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Putin's May 20 stop expected to proceed without ceremony:** Sources told SCMP the visit is routine and Chinese officials, still occupied with the Trump summit, plan no parade or formal welcome.
- **China set to have hosted all other P5 leaders within months:** After Putin's visit, Beijing will be the first country to receive Macron, Starmer, Trump, and Putin outside a multilateral setting, SCMP reports.

SCMP: "Taiwan's Cheng Li-wun on cross-strait peace, meeting Xi Jinping and managing ties with U.S.", 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **KMT chairwoman Cheng Li-wun frames the 1992 Consensus as the sole workable basis for cross-strait détente:** She argues accepting it would produce immediate goodwill, citing Ma Ying-jeou's 2008 - 2016 presidency as proof.
- **Cheng attributes a decade of cross-strait deterioration to DPP's rejection of the consensus:** She describes current tensions as a product of political engineering, contrasting them with the diplomatic truce achievable under KMT governance.

AP: "Takeaways from Trump's trip to China: Taiwan, a new framework for relationship and flattery for Xi", 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Trump deferred on Taiwan arms citing war risk:** Aboard Air Force One, Trump declined to confirm the \$14 billion package, saying "the last thing we need is a war 9,500 miles away."
- **Trump appeared unable to recall Taiwan president Lai Ching-te's name:** The lapse came as Trump described Xi's warning that a push for independence would trigger confrontation, AP reporters noted.

Nikkei: "Trump's Latin American domino play blocks out China", 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **Pro-US governments proliferating across Latin America have eroded Chinese BRI footholds:** Elections in Honduras, Costa Rica, Chile, and Bolivia since 2025 elevated Washington-friendly leaders with no affinity toward Beijing.
- **Panama's BRI withdrawal and CK Hutchison port concession cancellation mark concrete Chinese losses:** Venezuela's capture by US forces and regional governments' dependence on US export markets are accelerating the tilt away from China.

FT: “U.S. imposes sanctions on Chinese companies for allegedly helping Iran”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **US sanctioned three Chinese satellite firms for Iran military support:** State Department targeted The Earth Eye, MizarVision, and Chang Guang Satellite Technology for supplying imagery used in strikes against US forces.
- **Sanctions land days before Trump’s state visit to Beijing:** The measures - targeting companies that helped Iran identify US military facilities during Operation Epic Fury - were announced as Trump prepares to depart for the Xi summit.

NYT: “Why Xi Doesn’t Need a Deal With Trump”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Trump withheld a \$13 billion Taiwan arms package before Beijing:** The delay was designed to avoid angering Xi, who is seeking further arms sale reductions and a US statement opposing Taiwan independence, the article reports.
- **Beijing’s summit priority is peer-power recognition, not trade relief:** Xi has sought US acknowledgment of China as an equal since 2012, according to Stimson Center analysts cited - framing stability as Beijing’s core goal over any specific concessions.

Reuters: “Trump wants China’s help on Iran. Beijing may have other ideas”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Washington held back from sanctioning major Chinese banks over Iran:** Treasury warned two unnamed institutions in April but took no further action, fearing the move could revive a retaliatory trade war, sources told Reuters.
- **China’s competing interests constrain pressure on Tehran:** Beijing wants the Strait of Hormuz open for its oil imports but treats Iran as a strategic counterweight to U.S. influence, analysts told Reuters.
- **Treasury officials privately concede Chinese banks are indispensable for Iran enforcement:** A source with direct knowledge told Reuters it is “impossible to enforce the sanctions on Iran without going after Chinese banks.”

5. Strategic implications and responses

Foreign Policy: “Chinese Hegemony Might Be Happening”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **Walt revises his prior assessment that Chinese regional hegemony was implausible:** Trump’s retreat from science investment, clean energy leadership, and Asian diplomacy has materially strengthened China’s relative position, the author argues.
- **Twelve Asian posts have no serving U.S. ambassador, most without nominees:** The author argues this diplomatic vacuum - combined with U.S. withdrawal from

dozens of international organizations - cedes influence forums where China is increasingly active.

- **Gallup now ranks China ahead of the United States in global popularity:** Walt describes this inversion as a “remarkable development” that should worry observers, as U.S. unilateralism gives Beijing room to project a benign international image.

Foreign Affairs: “America Has Lost Its Leverage Over China”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **Busan deal gives Beijing veto over U.S. export controls:** China suspended rare earth curbs; Washington withdrew a semiconductor loophole rule and pledged no new China-targeted export controls, the article reports.
- **Role reversal on summit optics hands China Taiwan leverage:** The author argues Beijing trades ceremony for concessions, aiming to soften U.S. language on Taiwan independence at the upcoming summit.
- **Decoupled U.S.-China diplomacy abandons alliance management function:** Trump’s Beijing trip is the first since 1998 without allied country stops, allowing Beijing to weaponize apparent rapprochement against U.S. partners.

Foreign Affairs: “Spheres by Default”, 2026-05-16, [Link](#)

- **Authors reframe sphere risk as functional and emergent by default:** China can consolidate an open Indo-Pacific sphere via AI infrastructure, development aid, and chip access without formal great-power agreement, the authors argue.
- **U.S. concessions and Iran-war depletion have materially accelerated sphere formation:** Arms-sale hesitation, USAID dismantling, and munitions exhaustion have measurably boosted Beijing’s accumulation of influence across Southeast Asia, the authors report.

NYT: “How the U.S. Is Trying to Ensure the Dollar’s Dominance During Economic Turmoil”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Bessent opens swap-line talks with Gulf and Asian allies:** The discussions, run through Treasury or the Fed, aim to ensure dollar supply in partner countries and reduce renminbi use in oil transactions.
- **China has signed 40-plus bilateral currency swaps since 2009:** The People’s Bank of China uses the lines to lend to developing countries and promote renminbi internationalisation, according to the Council on Foreign Relations.
- **CFR fellow calls dollar displacement a non-imminent, “inflated” threat:** Brad Setser argues oil exporters face discounts for accepting renminbi and that new U.S. swap lines serve little strategic purpose.

EUISS: “Beijing’s critical raw material weapon - And how to dismantle it”, 2026-05-07, [Link](#)

- **Mineral controls serve intelligence gathering and Taiwan deterrence, not retaliation alone:** The EUISS Chaillot Paper argues Beijing calibrated export restrictions to reinforce industrial dominance and coerce states acting against its core interests, with Taiwan isolation named explicitly.
- **Minerals weaponisation shifted Washington from export controls to G2 bargaining:** China’s leverage reshaped the tech war, forcing the U.S. to negotiate rather than hold non-negotiable positions, leaving Europe increasingly exposed to economic coercion, the paper argues.

GPPI: “Critical Raw Materials: Reducing Dependence on China”, , [Link](#)

- **EU CRM policy misaligned with China’s state-backed vertical dominance:** Permitting reform and financial derisking fail without stable long-term demand at commercially viable prices, the study argues.
- **Demand-side gap is the primary shortcoming across all policy levers:** Revenue guarantees and sourcing rules - tools Japan and the U.S. deploy - are absent from EU measures.
- **Three-track fix: demand-price interventions, public-private stockpiling, and scaled recycling:** Berlin should lead EU-level CRM fund pooling and drive plurilateral action, not wait on U.S. initiatives.

FT: “Carmakers fear production hit after EU sanctions on Chinese chipmaker”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **EU sanctioned Yangjie in April for supplying dual-use technology to Russia:** The 20th sanctions package imposed an asset freeze and full trade ban; Yangjie denies producing or selling military-use products.
- **EU officials considering a carmaker derogation to avert a production crisis:** Executives warn disruption could arrive soon, citing dependence on Yangjie that grew after the 2024 Nexperia supply breakdown nearly halted chip flows to European plants.

NYT: “Spies, Sanctions, Cyberattacks: China and the U.S. Clash Behind the Scenes”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **White House no-confrontation order overtaken by pre-summit China moves:** Treasury sanctions, espionage charges against a California mayor, and a joint cybersecurity bulletin with allies all landed in the weeks before Trump’s Beijing visit.
- **Chinese hackers breached the FBI’s domestic surveillance order database:** The intrusion built on a prior FBI network compromise and targeted records of the bureau’s surveillance targets, the Times reports.

- **China hawks used summit timing to surface Beijing threat evidence:** Officials said the measures were designed partly to remind Trump of ongoing Chinese threats, not just to signal Beijing.

Politico: “EU Commission plans new squeeze on Chinese trade”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **EU Commission drafts expanded safeguard probes and new overcapacity instrument:** Brussels circulated a “more assertive” trade defense policy proposal targeting state-subsidized Chinese imports, to be discussed by EU leaders at a June 18 European Council, according to Politico.
- **EU-China trade deficit widened to €359.3bn in 2025, up nearly a fifth year-on-year:** European industrial sectors in chemicals and automotive are shedding jobs as lower-priced Chinese goods undercut domestic production.
- **Proposed overcapacity instrument carries WTO incompatibility risk:** Officials acknowledge the mechanism - targeting single-country state subsidies - would likely violate WTO rules barring discrimination against individual members.

AHK: “Flash Survey May 2026: Slightly More Positive Business Outlook Despite Impact of Geopolitical Escalations”, , [Link](#)

- **German companies in China most optimistic since 2023:** 37% predict economic improvement over the next six months, up 22 percentage points from 2025, and 61% plan to raise China investments within two years.
- **Iran war disrupts three-quarters of German firms in China:** 75% report operational impacts, led by rising logistics costs (55%) and higher supply prices (47%), according to the AHK flash survey.
- **EU dependency-reduction push tops German firms’ EU-China business concerns:** 52% cite the EU’s efforts to cut China dependencies as their primary concern, ahead of overcapacity and trade balance issues (40%).

FT: “France presses EU to crack down on platforms like Shein and Temu”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **France found 46% of tested foreign marketplace products nonconforming or dangerous:** Authorities withdrew over 100,000 items since April 2025 and tripled marketplace testing, with Shein and Temu accounting for the worst non-compliance rates.
- **Paris urges EU to impose sanctions of up to 4% annual turnover on non-compliant platforms:** DGCCRF head Sarah Lacoche called for forceful enforcement of existing digital consumer law, warning that weak implementation creates unfair competition for compliant rivals.

SCMP: “Netherlands protests U.S. proposal to further bar chip giant ASML from China market”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **Netherlands lodges official objection to MATCH Act over extraterritoriality:** Dutch Trade Minister Sjoerd Sjoerdsma communicated The Hague’s concerns to Congress and the US government about the proposed bill’s impact on ASML.
- **MATCH Act would bar ASML’s DUV sales and China servicing:** The bipartisan US bill introduced last month extends existing EUV restrictions to lower-end equipment and prohibits maintenance of Chinese customer machines.

Nikkei: “Led by industry, Japan and Taiwan plant seeds of drone cooperation”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **Fifteen Japan-Taiwan drone agreements signed since 2020:** Industry groups are building a “non-red” supply chain to reduce both countries’ dependence on Chinese drone components, according to DSET analysis.
- **China supplies over 90% of Japan’s civilian drone market:** Japan imported 124,936 Chinese units in 2025; Taiwan exported just 45 drones to Japan, against 120,000-plus shipped to Poland, the Czech Republic, and the US.
- **Japan targets 80,000 domestically produced drones by 2030:** METI’s plan emphasises like-minded partner cooperation, but analysts say Japan’s industrial ecosystem gap leaves Taiwanese firms few suitable counterparts for supply or joint tenders.

ECFR: “Trump in Beijing: Why the game stays the same for Europe”, 2026-05-13, [Link](#)

- **Author frames summit outcome as wary US-China détente:** Washington’s tariff retreat convinced it Beijing holds escalation dominance; both sides find the standoff serviceable, the article argues.
- **Author warns Europeans against deal FOMO and transatlantic China cooperation hopes:** Chinese purchasing commitments on soybeans or Boeing would not change European policy calculus, the author argues.
- **French government foresight body warns Chinese competition threatens two-thirds of Germany’s domestic output:** The report raises the prospect that entire segments of European industry could collapse within years.

IW: “Handel: Was der US-China-Gipfel für die deutsche Wirtschaft bedeutet”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **IW Köln warns EU is sidelined in the Trump-Xi Peking summit on tariffs:** The commentary argues European trade interests play no role in the negotiations despite significant exposure to their outcome.
- **Germany faces a rare earths squeeze regardless of deal terms:** If the US secures preferential raw material supply from China, Beijing may tighten export restrictions on

Europe to deter EU action against Chinese market distortions, according to the author.

Brookings: “Trump’s dangerous Taiwan gamble”, 2026-05-16, [Link](#)

- **Trump’s Taiwan stance raises war risk, Hass argues:** Expressing sympathy for Xi’s independence framing and treating arms sales as leverage will embolden Beijing to press harder on Taipei.
- **Trump offered a concession Beijing considers already settled:** China views the 1982 communiqué as locking in US arms sales reductions, so Trump surrendered credibility without benefit, the author contends.

Caixin: “U.K. Moves to Fully Nationalize Chinese-Owned British Steel”, 2026-05-15, [Link](#)

- **UK introduced legislation to nationalize Chinese-owned British Steel:** The Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill grants the government power to take British Steel and other steelmakers into public ownership on public interest grounds.
- **China’s commerce ministry demanded protection of Hebei Jingye’s investor rights:** Jingye acquired British Steel in 2020 for £53 million and invested over £1.2 billion, despite daily losses of £700,000, before the UK assumed de facto control in 2025.

NYT: “U.S.-China Rivalry Reaches South American Skies”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **US pressure halted two Chinese telescope projects in the Andes:** Argentina froze key antenna parts at customs for nine months; Chile blocked a 100-telescope Atacama observatory, both following sustained American diplomatic pressure.
- **Officials cited dual-use satellite risks across two administrations:** Washington told both governments the observatories could track US satellites or relay Chinese ones, enforcing restrictions through Sandia lab briefings and bilateral trade agreement clauses barring civilian-flagged Chinese space installations.

Foreign Policy: “What Happened to Trump the China Hawk?”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **China’s rare earth retaliation caught the Trump team off guard:** A former official told FP the Liberation Day tariff response generated lasting caution and drove Trump’s pivot toward bilateral stability.
- **Beijing’s summit goal is locking Trump into serial dialogues:** According to former NSC China director Liza Tobin, China calculates recurring face-to-face meetings will constrain the Trump bureaucracy from imposing new controls or tariffs between summits.

CFR: “What the Iran War Taught China About Fighting the United States”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **Iran war models economic coercion for China’s Taiwan planners:** The authors argue Beijing can replicate Iran’s Hormuz leverage through maritime quarantine, cyber pressure, and financial disruption short of invasion.
- **US munitions drain in the Middle East weakens Asia deterrence:** The article contends that visible multi-theater strain and long replenishment timelines reduce the credibility of US commitments to Taiwan in Chinese strategic calculations.

CFR: “Why Are More U.S. Allies Exploring Ties with China?”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Nine US allies met Xi in Beijing since 2025:** Western officials account for roughly half of all diplomatic visits to China during Trump’s second term, according to CFR’s analysis.
- **Canada and UK secured concrete tariff concessions from Beijing:** China cut Canadian canola oil tariffs from 85% to 15% and halved UK Scotch whisky tariffs to 5%, generating an estimated \$400 million over five years.
- **Experts describe the diplomatic engagement as “more style than substance”:** CFR analysts say the visits express frustration with Washington rather than a genuine strategic pivot, as US ecosystem embeddedness limits real tech or security realignment.

Economist: “Does Europe need to play America and China at their own trade game?”, 2026-05-12, [Link](#)

- **EU trade chief outlined his two-front trade war strategy:** Sefcovic discussed managing simultaneous pressure from Washington and Beijing in a recorded Economist interview, as free-trade orthodoxy faces what the show describes as unprecedented attack.
- **The Economist asked whether Europe must mirror US-China trade tactics:** The episode frames Europe’s dilemma as choosing between defending decades of trade openness or adopting more assertive, reciprocal measures to survive.

PIIE: “Fentanyl, China, and Trump’s 2025 tariffs”, 2026-05-11, [Link](#)

- **PIIE research found 2019 US-China fentanyl deal cut overdose deaths by ~1,000:** The agreement temporarily raised street prices before trafficking rerouted through Mexico, limiting its lasting impact.
- **Fentanyl purity began declining in late 2023, predating Trump’s 2025 tariffs:** A Science paper links the supply squeeze to Chinese precursor chemical crackdowns following the November 2023 Biden-Xi summit.

Reuters: “China ‘very disappointed’ with Europe’s planned investment restrictions, diplomat says”, 2026-05-14, [Link](#)

- **Beijing warned EU investment curbs risk a Chinese “door-closing” response:** Qu Xun, China’s commercial representative in Madrid, cited three months of European controls and sanctions as making China “very disappointed.”
- **Beijing lobbied to strip origin and “high-risk” provisions from EU legislation:** China pushed to remove procurement and technology requirements from the EU manufacturing rules and dilute “high-risk” definitions in EU cybersecurity bills.
- **Chinese diplomat conceded European firms face real market access barriers in China:** Qu said “the world is cruel” and European complaints about restricted sectors were valid, while calling on both sides to respect rules.

IV. GERMAN MEDIA LENS

Caveat: nur stichprobenartig auf Qualität/Richtigkeit überprüft – Coverage nur bis 15. Mai 2026

1. Prominente Zitate und Positionen zu China-bezogenen Angelegenheiten

- **Donald Trump bekräftigte** am Donnerstag in Peking bei seinem ersten Staatsbesuch seit neun Jahren die Vision einer neuen Kooperation und sagte: „Wir sollten Partner und nicht Rivalen sein“, wobei er den Fokus demonstrativ auf Handelsabschlüsse statt auf strategische Konflikte legte. (Source: „TRUMP IN PEKING; “Wir sollten Partner und nicht Rivalen sein”“, faz.net, 14. Mai 2026).
- **Xi Jinping warnte den US-Präsidenten** am Donnerstag in Peking eindringlich vor der Thukydides-Falle und erklärte bezüglich der Unterstützung Taiwans, dass eine falsche Handhabung dieser Frage die Beziehungen in eine „äußerst gefährliche Lage bringen“ könne. (Source: „USA-China-Gipfel in Peking; Wie verlogen ist dieser Handschlag?“, bild.de, 14. Mai 2026).
- **Xi Jinping versuchte** am Donnerstag beim Empfangsbankett in der Großen Halle des Volkes den Wettbewerb zu relativieren und sagte laut Xinhua: „Im Himmel ist für beide [USA und China] Platz“, man müsse die wichtigste bilaterale Beziehung der Welt nicht vermässeln. (Source: „TRUMP IN PEKING; “Wir sollten Partner und nicht Rivalen sein”“, faz.net, 14. Mai 2026).
- **Donald Trump lobte seinen Gastgeber** am Donnerstag in Peking in gewohnt überschwänglicher Manier als „großartige Führungspersönlichkeit“ und betonte mehrfach: „Es ist eine Ehre, Ihr Freund zu sein.“ (Source: „USA und China; Trump lädt Chinas Staatschef Xi in die USA ein“, zeit.de, 14. Mai 2026).
- **Friedrich Merz forderte** am Donnerstag in seiner Laudatio zur Karlspreis-Verleihung in Aachen, dass Europa angesichts der Großmachtpolitik der USA und Chinas endlich „eine Macht werden“ müsse, um nicht zum Spielball zu degenerieren. (Source: „Karlspreis-Verleihung; Merz: Europa muss „eine Macht werden““, wiwo.de, 14. Mai 2026).

- **Markus Söder kündigte** am Freitag in München eine Regierungserklärung an, in der er darlegen will, wie Bayern als Spitzenstandort für Hightech „gegenüber den USA und China wettbewerbsfähig bleibt“. (Source: „Südkorea hält Kim Jong-uns Tochter für Nachfolgerin [Kontext Bayern-Spezial]“, Süddeutsche Zeitung, 15. Mai 2026).
- **Marco Rubio setzte** am Freitag bei der Sicherung der Straße von Hormus offen auf die Kooperation Pekings und betonte, dass die Chinesen als exportorientierte Wirtschaft „ein eigenes Interesse an einer Lösung“ der Seeblockade hätten. (Source: „Diplomatie; Rubio: USA setzen bei Straße von Hormus auf Hilfe aus China“, wiwo.de, 15. Mai 2026).
- **He Lifeng (Vize-Ministerpräsident Chinas) bezeichnete die vorbereitenden Handelsgespräche mit US-Finanzminister Bessent** am Mittwoch in Südkorea als „offen und konstruktiv“, was den Weg für die symbolträchtigen Abschlüsse in Peking ebnete. (Source: „Dax aktuell; Dax eröffnet im Plus – Trump-Xi-Treffen im Fokus“, handelsblatt.com, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Scott Bessent (US-Finanzminister) bewertete die Verhandlungen mit seinem chinesischen Counterpart** am Donnerstag in Peking als Erfolg und sprach von „balancierten und positiven Ergebnissen“ für die Weltwirtschaft. (Source: „STAATSBEUCH IN PEKING; Xi setzt Trump die Pistole auf die Brust“, faz.net, 14. Mai 2026).
- **Dan Wang (Ökonom und Philosoph) kritisierte die deutsche Wachstumskultur** am Donnerstag scharf und konstatierte: „Für mich fühlt sich ganz Europa wie ein Mausoleum an“, da Steuern zu hoch und Anreize für ruchlose Entschlossenheit zu gering seien. (Source: „Dan Wang; »Für mich fühlt sich ganz Europa wie ein Mausoleum an«“, zeit.de, 14. Mai 2026).
- **Anders Fogh Rasmussen (Ehemaliger NATO-Generalsekretär) forderte** am Dienstag den Aufbau eines neuen Staatenbündnisses („D7“ – D für demokratisch) als Alternative zur G7, da die „Unberechenbarkeit Donald Trumps“ und Chinas Machtansprüche neue Allianzen erforderten. (Source: „D7 statt G7? Früherer Nato-Chef wirbt für Aufbau von neuem Staatenbündnis“, wiwo.de, 12. Mai 2026).
- **Katherina Reiche (Bundwirtschaftsministerin, CDU) kündigte** am Dienstag in Berlin ihren baldigen Antrittsbesuch in Peking an, wobei Beobachter davon ausgehen, dass die Volksrepublik die europäischen „Pilger“ angesichts der US-Zollpolitik zurückgelehnt empfangen wird. (Source: „STAATSBESUCH IN PEKING; Trumps Werk und Chinas Beitrag“, faz.net, 12. Mai 2026).
- **Frank Bösenberg (Geschäftsführer Silicon Saxony) beklagte** am Freitag in Dresden das deutsche Umsetzungstempo gegenüber Asien: „Die Politik ist wahnsinnig langsam.“ (Source: „Halbleiter; Angst ums Silicon Saxony – „Wir fallen de facto zurück““, handelsblatt.com, 15. Mai 2026).
- **Lars Reger (Technikvorstand NXP) stellte** am Freitag die ökonomische Logik europäischer Chip-Souveränität infrage: „Die Frage ist: Sind die Kunden bereit, für europäische Chips mehr Geld auszugeben?“ (Source: „Halbleiter; Angst ums Silicon Saxony – „Wir fallen de facto zurück““, handelsblatt.com, 15. Mai 2026).
- **Qimin Fei (Analyst, First Sentier) bezeichnete den chinesischen Markt** am Freitag als große Chance für Anleger, da das Umfeld sich stabilisiere und „die

Bewertungen der Unternehmen attraktiv sind“. (Source: „Diese Chancen in China übersehen gerade viele Anleger“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 15. Mai 2026).

- **Sarah Speicher-Utsch (Finanzexpertin) analysierte** am Freitag, dass der chinesische Aktienmarkt 2025 um fast ein Drittel zugelegt habe und damit eine „große Chance“ für jene darstelle, die das Land nicht länger ignorieren wollen. (Source: „Diese Chancen in China übersehen gerade viele Anleger“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 15. Mai 2026).
- **Milan Nedeljkovic (BMW-Produktionsvorstand/designierter Chef) wurde** am Mittwoch als das „Gegenmodell zum schillernden Topmanager“ porträtiert, der die neue Konzernstrategie im Schatten der China-Krise umsetzen müsse. (Source: „Autoindustrie; Neuer BMW-Chef macht Vertrauten zum Konzernstrategen“, handelsblatt.com, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Wang Yiwei (Professor, Renmin-Universität) verteidigte** am Montag den Einsatz ökonomischer Druckmittel durch Peking: „Israel nutzt ihn, andere Länder nutzen ihn. Warum sollte China ihn nicht nutzen?“ (Source: „Trump in Peking; Der Unberechenbare wird kalkulierbar“, wiwo.de, 11. Mai 2026).
- **Alicia Garcia Herrero (Chefökonomin Natixis) warnte** am Dienstag, dass der Iran-Krieg die „Risse in Chinas Wirtschaft“ zwar beleuchtet habe, Peking aber seine Macht in der Energiekrise dennoch weiter ausbaue. (Source: „HANDELSBLATT – GASTKOMMENTAR – ; China profitiert vom Irankrieg, hat aber strukturelle Defizite“, Handelsblatt, 12. Mai 2026).
- **Holger Schmidt (FAZ-Autor) konstatierte** am Dienstag zum technologischen Wettlauf: „Wer wissen will, wer an der KI-Welle verdient, muss der Wertschöpfungskette folgen.“ (Source: „SANDISK, CORNING & CO; Die 50 Unternehmen, die am KI-Boom definitiv verdienen“, faz.net, 12. Mai 2026).
- **Jens Mühling (Journalist) analysierte** am Donnerstag die veränderte Machtbalance: „Zuletzt hat sich die Machtbalance zwischen China und den USA gründlich verändert – nicht gerade zu Donald Trumps Gunsten.“ (Source: „Donald Trump in China; Auf der Agenda: Sojabohnen und zwei Kriege“, zeit.de, 14. Mai 2026).

2. Wichtige China-bezogenen Entwicklungen in Fakten und Zahlen

- **Unitree-Börsengang in Sicht:** Der führende chinesische Hersteller humanoider Roboter, Unitree, bereitet seinen Börsengang vor; Analysten schätzen die Bewertung des Unternehmens bereits auf rund 5,9 Milliarden Dollar. (Source: „BörsenTag; Diese chinesischen Aktien sind aktuell attraktiv“, wiwo.de, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Divergenz der Tech-Indizes:** Während der Nasdaq 100 in den letzten fünf Jahren um 130 Prozent zulegte, verlor das chinesische Pendant, der Hang Seng Tech Index, im gleichen Zeitraum ein Drittel seines Wertes. (Source: „Chinas vergessene KI-Aktien“, Die Welt, 15. Mai 2026).
- **Trumps geheimes Apple-Portfolio:** Vor seiner China-Reise investierte US-Präsident Donald Trump massiv in den Tech-Konzern Apple; laut Daten der Ethikbehörde kaufte er im ersten Quartal 2026 Papiere im Wert von bis zu 7,2

Millionen Dollar. (Source: „Tech-Konzern; Trump investierte vor China-Reise Millionen Dollar in Apple“, handelsblatt.com, 15. Mai 2026).

- **Rekord-Jahresziele für Merck:** Getrieben durch die Nachfrage aus der Halbleiterindustrie hob Merck seine Ziele für 2026 an und erwartet nun einen Umsatz zwischen 20,4 und 21,4 Milliarden Euro. (Source: „Dax im Plus – Pharma-Aktie springt acht Prozent nach oben“, handelsblatt.com, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Sojabohnen-Flugzeug-Deal:** Als Teil der Gipfel-Ergebnisse stellte China den Kauf amerikanischer Flugzeuge (Boeing) sowie massiver Mengen Sojabohnen aus Trump-freundlichen US-Bundesstaaten in Aussicht. (Source: „F.A.Z. FRÜHDENKER“, faz.net, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Erosion der Bildungsinvestitionen:** Neue Zahlen von McKinsey belegen, dass deutsche Unternehmen ihre Budgets für die Weiterbildung ihrer Mitarbeiter um 30 Prozent gekürzt haben, während China massiv in Humankapital investiert. (Source: „PERSONAL; Budgets für Weiterbildung um 30 Prozent gekürzt“, Handelsblatt, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Chinas Kerosin-Vorteil:** Die Internationale Energieagentur (IEA) warnt, dass europäische Fluggesellschaften wie die Lufthansa infolge der Hormus-Blockade bereits 20.000 Flüge streichen mussten, während China seine Energieversorgung diversifiziert. (Source: „Dass die Lufthansa zuletzt 20.000 Flüge gestrichen hat, ist kein Zufall“, Die Welt, 8. Mai 2026).
- **Absage an RWTH Aachen:** Die Universität Aachen sagte eine geplante Jobbörse mit chinesischen Unternehmen ab, nachdem der Verfassungsschutz vor der gezielten Rekrutierung an Exzellenz-Unis warnte; allein in Aachen forschen 4.000 Chinesen. (Source: „SICHERHEIT; Wie China auf deutsche Exzellenz-Unis zielt“, Handelsblatt, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Öl-Fakturierung in Yuan:** Chinesische Raffinerien wickeln ihre Importe aus dem Iran und Russland inzwischen fast vollständig in Yuan ab, um US-Sanktionen zu umgehen. (Source: „Ein Deal und sonst nicht viel“, faz.net, 13. Mai 2026).
- **Schrumpfendes Silicon Saxony:** Dresden verzeichnet erstmals einen Rückgang bei Neuprojekten im Halbleiterbereich, während asiatische Standorte ihr Investitionsvolumen um 37 Prozent steigerten. (Source: „Halbleiter; Angst ums Silicon Saxony – „Wir fallen de facto zurück““, handelsblatt.com, 15. Mai 2026).

3. Fünf zentrale Themen in der deutschen China-Politik Diskussion

- **Taiwan als “Verhandlungsmasse” – Das Ende der US-Sicherheitsgarantien?** Die Berichterstattung über den Peking-Besuch von Donald Trump ist von tiefer Sorge über eine strategische Kehrtwende Washingtons geprägt. Während US-Präsidenten wie Joe Biden die Verteidigung Taiwans zur Staatsräson erklärten, wird Trump in deutschen Medien als “Dealmaker” wahrgenommen, für den Taiwan lediglich ein Hebel für bessere Handelsbedingungen bei Sojabohnen und Boeing-Flugzeugen ist. Die Diskussion fokussiert sich auf das Schweigen Trumps zu Xis harten Warnungen und die daraus resultierende Schutzlosigkeit des für die globale Chipindustrie essenziellen Inselstaats. Prominente Quellen: „Taiwan wird Verhandlungsmasse“, Süddeutsche Zeitung, 15. Mai 2026; „Xi setzt Trump die Pistole auf die Brust“,

faz.net, 14. Mai 2026; „So brandgefährlich ist die Schwäche der USA für Taiwan“, wiwo.de, 15. Mai 2026.

- **Der „DeepSeek-Moment“ und die finanzielle Rehabilitation Chinas:** Ein zentrales Thema ist die Neubewertung chinesischer Tech-Aktien durch die Wall Street. Das Erscheinen des neuen chinesischen KI-Modells „DeepSeek-V4“, das technisch nur noch Monate hinter der US-Spitze liegen soll, hat den jahrelangen Konsens der „Uninvestierbarkeit“ Chinas erschüttert. Die Debatte dreht sich darum, ob die extrem niedrigen Bewertungen und der technologische Fortschritt Pekings einen massiven Kapitalrückfluss aus den USA nach China auslösen werden, ungeachtet der politischen Systemrivalität. Prominente Quellen: „Chinas vergessene KI-Aktien“, Die Welt, 15. Mai 2026; „DeepSeek-V4-Modell hält China an Weltspitze“, Handelsblatt, 15. Mai 2026; „Diese Chancen in China übersehen gerade viele Anleger“, faz.net, 15. Mai 2026.
- **Die „D7-Architektur“ als Antwort auf die NATO-Erosion:** Angesichts der Unberechenbarkeit Donald Trumps und der militärischen Expansion Chinas wird in Deutschland verstärkt über alternative Sicherheitsbündnisse debattiert. Der Vorschlag des ehemaligen NATO-Chefs Rasmussen, eine „D7-Allianz“ der führenden Demokratien (inkl. Japan und Australien) zu gründen, wird als notwendige Versicherung gegen einen Rückzug der USA aus ihrer Führungsrolle gewertet. Die Diskussion markiert eine Abkehr von der totalen Abhängigkeit von Washington hin zu einer eigenständigen, globalen Sicherheitsarchitektur. Prominente Quellen: „D7 statt G7?“, wiwo.de, 12. Mai 2026; „Früherer Nato-Chef wirbt für Aufbau von neuem Staatenbündnis“, zeit.de, 12. Mai 2026; „Was diese zwei Männer besprechen, hat Folgen für die ganze Welt“, Spiegel Online, 13. Mai 2026.
- **Der „Bauplan für ein neues Wirtschaftswunder“ als industrieller Weckruf:** In der Wirtschaftspresse formiert sich zum 80. Jubiläum des Handelsblatts eine Debatte über die kulturellen und strukturellen Ursachen des deutschen Abstiegs gegenüber China. Experten fordern einen radikalen „Bauplan“, der sich an den Erfolgsmodellen von Shenzhen und Bangalore orientiert: Konzentration auf Schlüsseltechnologien statt Gießkannen-Förderung, enge Verzahnung von Forschung und Industrie sowie eine Abkehr vom „Mausoleum-Gefühl“ europäischer Trägheit. Experten wie Dan Wang werfen der deutschen Gesellschaft einen Mangel an „Ruchlosigkeit“ und „Geldhunger“ vor, während man sich in Bürokratie und Selbstmitleid („Jammerei“) verliere. Das Thema kontrastiert den chinesischen „Ingenieursstaat“ mit dem deutschen „Politikerstaat“ und fordert eine radikale Rückbesinnung auf industrielle Härte, um im „Gesetz des Dschungels“ der neuen Weltordnung zu bestehen. Prominente Quellen: „Morning Briefing; Der Bauplan für ein neues Wirtschaftswunder“, handelsblatt.com, 15. Mai 2026; „EDITORIAL; Warum das Handelsblatt heute anders aussieht“, Handelsblatt, 15. Mai 2026; „Dan Wang: Ganz Europa fühlt sich wie ein Mausoleum an“, zeit.de, 14. Mai 2026.
- **Wissenschaftssicherheit an „Exzellenz-Unis“ im Visier der Geheimdienste:** Ein neues Eskalationsniveau in der Debatte um den Know-how-Abfluss wird durch den Fall der RWTH Aachen markiert. Die Absage einer chinesischen Jobbörse nach Warnungen des Verfassungsschutzes hat eine Diskussion über die „Naivität“ der Hochschulen ausgelöst. Die Diskussion thematisiert, dass China gezielt an deutschen Spitzenstandorten rekrutiert, während die Politik bei der Umsetzung einer nationalen Plattform für Forschungssicherheit und der Überprüfung von Stipendiaten

(CSC) hinterherhinkt. Prominente Quellen: „SICHERHEIT; Wie China auf deutsche Exzellenz-Unis zielt“, Handelsblatt, 13. Mai 2026; „Wissenschaftssicherheit ist kein „Nice to have““, Der Tagesspiegel, 15. Mai 2026; „Halbleiter; Angst ums Silicon Saxony“, handelsblatt.com, 15. Mai 2026.